

followers widens not through access to better models—those are freely available—but through their ability to deploy them systematically.

The question facing leadership teams is increasingly clear. As open source models approach or exceed proprietary model performance across narrow domains, and as deployment tools mature towards commodity status, competitive advantage accrues to organisations that move fastest from strategy to architecture to production at scale.

The quiet revolution in efficient AI is creating a window of opportunity measured in quarters, not years. Organisations that master the architecture, operations, and business integration of small language models are building sustainable advantages in an AI-enabled world. Those who wait for perfect clarity or mature platforms may find that the advantage has already been claimed by faster-moving competitors.

The infrastructure exists. The models are available. The case studies validate the approach. The remaining variable is organisational will and

execution velocity. The leaders of 2026 will be defined not by who talks about AI strategy, but by who deploys it into production this quarter.  **END**

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